

Call Prep: Nexben Discussion with Improving

Meeting: Today, Wednesday, July 1, 2026 @ 4:00 PM ET / 3:00 PM CT (30 min, Teams)

Attendees: Lauren Sweda (CGO, organizer), Mark Smith (CEO), David O'Hara, Alexander Powell

Goal: Understand the new "broader tech needs" ask, confirm the contract-to-hire model fits, and get this account moving again after four months of stall.

Account Snapshot

Field	Value
Company	Nexben
HQ	1430 Monroe Ave NW, Suite 180, Grand Rapids, MI 49505
Industry	Healthcare Benefits / Fintech
What They Do	End-to-end benefits utility hub for defined contribution & ICHRA — brokers, employers, employees
Revenue	~\$3.5M (2024)
Team Size	~57 people
Dev Model	~90% outsourced to a single third-party vendor; no in-house developers; a planned CTO hire fell through when the candidate unexpectedly passed away before starting
CRM Status	Open Dynamics opportunity from March ("Insurance Pricing Tool Discovery," \$15K) — likely needs updating after today

Who's in the Room

Lauren Sweda — Chief Growth Officer

lsweda@nexben.com | D: 612.464.4733 | C: 469.866.1601 | Frisco, TX (remote). Previously at Magellan Health and Careington. Neighbor connection — mention it again, it's an easy warm-up.

Mark Smith — CEO

msmith@nexben.com. First call with him directly. He's the one Lauren has had to "wow" to keep any Improving engagement moving — treat this as the real decision-maker conversation.

Alexander Powell — Improving Account Manager

On your side. He's been the one keeping this account warm through the silence (March 31, April 21 follow-ups) and negotiated the contract-to-hire framing with Lauren on June 27/29.

Discovery Questions

On the core problem

- 1 "What's the specific thing that made you say the current model isn't sustainable — cost, speed, quality, or all three?"
- 2 "How big is your current backlog with the outsourced vendor, and how much of it is stuff you'd want an in-house or dedicated team handling instead?"
- 3 "Are you looking to build toward a fully in-house team eventually, or do you want an ongoing blended model?"

On contract-to-hire specifics

- 4 "How many roles are you thinking about to start — one, a small team?"
- 5 "What functions first — the pricing tool build, platform engineering, something else entirely?"
- 6 "What's your timeline to have someone in seat?"
- 7 "Who owns hiring decisions once someone's ready to convert — you, Mark, HR?"

On the pricing tool

- 8 "Is the pricing analysis tool still a live need? Did you solve it another way since March, or is it still sitting on your desk?"

Talking Points

Topic	What to Say
Continuity	Acknowledge you never fully lost the thread — Alexander followed up in March and April; glad it's back on.
Healthcare/fintech credibility	Same references as before: Westfield Insurance, Centene, Zipnosis, Thrivent — 18 years building in regulated data environments.
Contract-to-hire fit	This model is built for exactly this situation: get capacity in the door fast without a long-term headcount commitment, then convert once you've proven fit.
Neighbor angle	Still true, still works — use it to keep the tone warm with Lauren, especially in front of Mark.

Watch For

- Scope ambiguity — "Broader tech needs" is vague. Don't leave without at least one concrete role or workstream identified.
- Why now — Something likely triggered this after three months of silence. Worth probing gently (budget cycle, a bad vendor incident, a board conversation).
- Mark Smith's read — This is your first real signal of how the CEO thinks about build vs. buy vs. staff. Listen for how much technical fluency he has and how involved he wants to be going forward.
- Pricing tool zombie risk — Don't let it get talked around; get an explicit answer on its status so the CRM opportunity can be closed, updated, or reactivated accurately.